But later on, sitting alone on his terrace, Banarasi had other thoughts.

The seventeen-year-old Jain of eclectic faith had only recently been disappointed by his purchase of a mantra meant to bring gold to his door. Soon after, he had taken to worshipping Shiva. But now he asked himself why: ‘When I swooned and fell, / Shiva did not help me then.’ Banarasi stopped his daily puja to the Lord.

Abul Fazl might have liked the story, and Akbar too: that his death bred doubt in his young subject.

Perhaps, they might have said, Akbar’s soul did escape into the world through that patch on his skull. Perhaps his famously, notoriously, adventurous spirit found its way to Jaunpur, flew up to the pensive poet on his roof and whispered in his ear: Question. Doubt. Scandalize.